

Module 7: Migration Through History

Graduate Research Project

Continuity and Rupture: Comparing a Historical and a Contemporary Migration Regime

Overview

A comparative-historical essay analyzing one past migration regime alongside its closest contemporary analogue (e.g., 1920s US quotas and modern visa caps; guest-worker programs then and now; post-WWII displacement and today's protection system).

Aligned learning outcomes

- Analyze continuity and rupture in migration regimes (Grad 1)

Sample research questions

- What problem did each regime claim to solve, and whom did it actually serve?
- Which mechanisms (categories, quotas, enforcement, documentation) persist across the century, and which genuinely changed?
- What does the historical case predict about the contemporary regime's trajectory?

Methods

Comparative-historical analysis using at least four primary sources (laws, speeches, agency records, contemporary press) plus scholarship. Explicit comparison framework — not two separate summaries.

IRB / research ethics

Not required — archival and published sources.

Deliverables

- 4,500–5,500-word comparative essay with a continuity/rupture analysis table
- Annotated primary source appendix

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Primary source depth 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: primary source depth is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: primary source depth is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: primary source depth is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: primary source depth is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Rigor of the comparative framework 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: rigor of the comparative framework goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: rigor of the comparative framework is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: rigor of the comparative framework is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: rigor of the comparative framework is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Argument quality on continuity vs. rupture 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: argument quality on continuity vs. rupture goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: argument quality on continuity vs. rupture is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: argument quality on continuity vs. rupture is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: argument quality on continuity vs. rupture is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Writing and citation 15%	Communication is publication-ready: writing and citation is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: writing and citation is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: writing and citation is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: writing and citation is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.